Maximize My Retirement User's Guide

What this page is

Maximize My Retirement is a retirement planner in the browser. You enter ages, income, and balances. The page shows one row for every year from 2026 through the last age you enter. Tax in each row uses 2026 amounts.

Read this guide the first time you use the page. Start at the top. Each step says what you should see. Finish that step before you go on.

You will fill in your household. Then you will fill in Roth IRA, HSA, 401(k), and Taxable. Then you will read one year, let the planner choose Roth conversions, and save the plan as a file.

Open the page. The top line is the plan name, **Retirement plan**, and you can change it. That name is saved in the file, and **Save** uses it as the file name. Under it you should see **Maximize My Retirement**. A form is on the left, and a chart and table are on the right. The page starts from a sample, so you can match these values before you change them.

- **Year of Birth** is 1955. The hint under the field says age 71. That hint is 2026 minus the birth year.
- **Filing Status** is **Married**. **Marriage Year** is 2026. **Spouse Birth Year** is 1960.
- **Retirement Year** is 2026. **Longevity (Primary)** and **Longevity (Spouse)** are both 100.
- **Adjusted Gross Income** is empty. **Only the first year** is unchecked. **Social Security (Primary)** and **Social Security (Spouse)** are empty. Both **Start Age** fields are 67. **State** is Georgia.

The page does not store what you type. **Save** is in the header, next to the title. If you close the page before you click **Save**, the sample comes back.

Enter your household

Personal Information is the section at the top of the form on the left. You are the person in **Year of Birth**. Your spouse is the person in **Spouse Birth Year**. The planner uses 2026 tax amounts in every year.

1. Enter **Year of Birth**. You should see the hint change to your age in 2026. Your age is 2026 minus that year.
2. Set **Filing Status** to **Single** or **Married**. On **Married**, you should see **Marriage Year**, **Spouse Birth Year**, **Longevity (Spouse)**, and **Spouse**. On **Single**, those are hidden.
3. If you chose **Married**, enter **Marriage Year**. A year before that year is taxed as single, and your spouse is not in the plan yet. You should see the marriage fields only while the status is **Married**.
4. Enter **Spouse Birth Year**. The hint shows your spouse's age in 2026.
5. Enter **Longevity (Primary)**. If you are married, enter **Longevity (Spouse)**. **Year-by-Year Projection** is the table on the right. You should see its last row move to the later of those two ages. The longevity year shows that age with no parentheses. Every later year puts that age in parentheses. If your spouse lives longer, your age in the last row is past **Longevity (Primary)**, and it is in parentheses.

6. Enter **Retirement Year**. You are retired in that year and after it. Roth IRA, 401(k), and Taxable contributions stop then. You should see **Stop Contributing at Age** and **Start Withdrawing at Age** change on Roth IRA, 401(k), and Taxable. On each HSA, only **Start Withdrawing at Age** changes. HSA contributions stop at the age on that HSA, not in **Retirement Year**.
7. Type other income in **Adjusted Gross Income**. Other income is wages, a pension, or interest that you type as one number. A required distribution is the amount the tax rules force out of a 401(k). A Roth conversion moves money from a 401(k) into a Roth IRA. The **AGI** column in the table starts from this field. It then adds the taxable part of Social Security, required distributions, and Roth conversions.
8. Leave **Only the first year** unchecked to use that income every year. You should see the box unchecked when the page first opens. Check it to use the amount in 2026 only. Later years then use $0. A plan saved before this box existed also uses the amount every year.
9. Enter **Social Security (Primary)**. If you are married, enter **Social Security (Spouse)** too. Each amount is the annual check that person receives at the **Start Age** you enter, from 62 to 70. The planner does not estimate the check, and it does not add a spousal benefit on top of it. The year that check starts counts six months. The year that person dies counts six months, and that check stops. After a death, the survivor receives the larger of their own check and the survivor benefit on the person who died. The survivor benefit can start at 60. It is smaller before the survivor's full retirement age, and it does not stack on the survivor's own check. On **Single**, only your own **Social Security** field is shown.
10. Choose **State**. You should see the 50 states and the District of Columbia.

Nine of those places charge no income tax here. They are Alaska, Florida, Nevada, New Hampshire, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Washington, and Wyoming.

Georgia tax is 4.99% of income after the Georgia deduction and the retirement exclusion. Social Security is exempt. The deduction is $15,000 if the year is single and $30,000 if it is married. From age 62, each person can exclude $35,000 of money that leaves that person's own 401(k). From age 65, that exclusion is $65,000. **Adjusted Gross Income** counts toward your exclusion, not your spouse's.

Ohio charges no tax on the first $26,050. Above that, the tax is $332 plus 2.75% of the amount over $26,050.

Every other state uses its own 2026 tax rates. A bracket is the highest income taxed at one rate. Those brackets stay at 2026 amounts in every year of the table. They do not rise with inflation.

If you change **Filing Status**, open each HSA and read **Annual Contribution**. **Married** sets each HSA to $4,375. **Single** sets yours to $4,400. That reset is the field catching the HSA limit. The limit is $4,400 on a single return and $8,750 for a family. The married field uses half of the family limit for each spouse. The planner does not check that the two HSA amounts stay within $8,750 together.

Fill in a tab

The tabs under **Personal Information** are **Roth IRA**, **HSA**, **401(k)**, and **Taxable**. If you are married, choose **Primary** or **Spouse** first. **Primary** is you. Then choose a tab.

1. Choose **Roth IRA**, **HSA**, **401(k)**, or **Taxable**. **Spouse** has no **Taxable** tab. **Taxable** is only under **Primary**. The chart calls that balance **Taxable Brokerage**.
2. Turn the switch on at the top of the tab. On, that balance takes contributions, growth, and withdrawals. Off, you should see the fields fade, and the balance counts as $0.

3. Enter **Current Balance**. That is the balance at the start of 2026. Enter **Rate of Return**. Growth each year is that percent times the balance after the year's contribution and withdrawal. The sample rate is 8%.
4. Enter **Annual Contribution**. This is the dollars added each year while contributions continue. After 2026, the amount you typed grows by 3% a year. The limit in the label is the 2026 IRS limit at today's age. Catch-up is the extra the IRS adds to that limit from a set age. The limit already includes it. A later birthday does not add a new catch-up. The planner does not reduce a contribution above the limit.

Before catch-up, the 2026 amounts in those labels are:

- Roth IRA, $7,500
- HSA on a single return, $4,400
- HSA for each spouse, $4,375
- 401(k), $24,500

Catch-up in the label is $1,100 on a Roth IRA from age 50, and $1,000 on an HSA from age 55. On a 401(k) it is $8,000 from age 50. At ages 60, 61, 62, and 63 it is $11,250 instead of $8,000. Changing a birth year updates the contribution only when the field still equals the old limit.

5. On a 401(k), enter **Employer Match** if you have one. The match is added on top of **Annual Contribution** and grows 3% a year. It starts at $0.
6. On an HSA, set **Stop Contributing at Age**. That age stops the HSA only. Roth IRA, 401(k), and Taxable contributions ignore it and stop in **Retirement Year**.
7. Set **Start Withdrawing at Age**. A scheduled withdrawal starts then. An amount of $0 withdraws nothing.
8. Turn on **Use %** to withdraw a percent of the balance. The label becomes **Withdrawal %**. The withdrawal is that percent of the balance after the year's contribution. Leave **Use %** off to withdraw a fixed number of dollars. The label is then **Annual Withdrawal**. A dollar amount does not grow by 3%. The sample **Taxable** tab has **Use %** on and the percent at 0, and its contribution starts at $24,000.

A 401(k) also has Roth conversion controls. The column name for a required distribution is **RMD**. It starts once you reach the age for your birth year. Born in 1960 or later, that age is 75. Born from 1951 through 1959, it is 73. Born in 1949 or 1950, it is 72. Born before 1949, it is 70.

9. Turn on **Pre-RMD Roth Conversions** to allow conversions before that RMD age. Four things must all be true. The switch is on. The 401(k) is on. The year is a retired year. The person is 60 or older. You should see **10% Bracket** through **37% Bracket**. A choice below 37% stops the conversion before the next dollar would be taxed above that rate. The 37% choice does not add that stop.
10. Turn on **RMD Roth Conversions** for the same kind of conversion from the RMD age onward. Turning this switch off does not stop the required distribution. The distribution still leaves the 401(k).
11. If either of those switches is on, you should see **IRMAA Bracket Cap**. The menu starts with **No IRMAA cap**. The other lines are **Standard**, **Tier 1**, **Tier 2**, **Tier 3**, and **Tier 4**, each with a dollar cap.

IRMAA is the extra Medicare Part B and Part D premium caused by income from two years earlier. It is not the standard Part B premium of $202.90. That standard premium is never in the fee. **No IRMAA cap** means the conversion ignores IRMAA. The hint then reads "Conversions ignore Medicare IRMAA." A named tier

stops conversions when Medicare income reaches that tier. That income is MAGI. MAGI is the modified adjusted gross income Medicare uses. In this planner, MAGI is other income, plus the taxable part of Social Security, plus required distributions, plus Roth conversions.

If you and your spouse can both convert, and both have a cap, the lower cap applies. If the required distribution is already over the cap, the conversion that year is $0. The distribution is still taken.

The cap on the menu is the top of that tier. MAGI at or below the top stays in the tier. The hint names the cap, then joint MAGI or single MAGI, then the surcharge per person each month. Joint means married. Standard says no surcharge.

Menu tier	Single cap	Married cap	Surcharge per person each month
Standard	$109,000	$218,000	$0.00
Tier 1	$137,000	$274,000	$95.70
Tier 2	$171,000	$342,000	$240.40
Tier 3	$205,000	$410,000	$385.00
Tier 4	$499,999	$749,999	$529.60

Tier 5 is not in the menu, because it has no cap. MAGI of $500,000 or more on a single return, or $750,000 or more on a married return, is Tier 5. The monthly surcharge is $578.00 per person. The table still charges Tier 5. The menu cannot stop a conversion there.

12. Turn on **Pay Roth Conversion Taxes from Taxable Account** to pay that person's conversion tax from the taxable balance. Turn the switch off to withhold the tax from the Roth conversion. The Roth IRA then receives the conversion minus that tax. Tax on a required distribution is separate. The planner takes that tax from the taxable balance, up to the cash there, whether this switch is on or off.

Your 401(k) starts on. Your spouse's 401(k) starts off. Roth IRA and HSA contributions start at the 2026 limit for that person's age.

Read one year

The right side shows **At Retirement**, **Peak Portfolio Value**, **Dividends at Retirement**, and **Years to Retirement**. Then it shows **Portfolio Growth** and **Year-by-Year Projection**.

1. Read **At Retirement**. You should see the total balance in **Retirement Year**, at the age of that year minus **Year of Birth**.
2. Read **Peak Portfolio Value**. You should see the highest **Total** in the table, with the age and year of that row. **Total** is the Roth IRA, HSA, 401(k), and Taxable ending balances added together.
3. Read **Dividends at Retirement**. You should see 2% of the taxable balance in the retirement year, rounded to thousands of dollars. This figure is not a withdrawal, and it is not added to income.
4. Read **Years to Retirement**. You should see your retirement age minus your age in 2026, and never a number below 0. The detail line repeats the retirement age.
5. Rest the pointer on a year in **Portfolio Growth**. You should see a tip with each ending balance and the total. The areas are the 401(k), the Roth IRA, the HSA, and **Taxable Brokerage**. When **Spouse Birth Year** is set, the tip also shows both ages, with the same parentheses as **Age**.

6. Open **Year-by-Year Projection** and stay on **Summary**. You should see one row per year. **Year** is the calendar year. **Age** is your age. When **Spouse Birth Year** is set, **Age** is your age, then your spouse's age, including years before **Marriage Year**. After your longevity year, your age is in parentheses. After your spouse's longevity year, your spouse's age is in parentheses. The longevity year itself has no parentheses.

Read the summary columns from left to right. Each name means the following on every row.

- **Roth IRA**, **HSA**, **401(k)**, and **Taxable** are ending balances. Spouses are combined. The **Taxable** column is the household taxable balance.
- **Total** is those four balances added together.
- **Spendable** is **Total** after the cost of cashing out the 401(k) and HSA balances that remain. Roth IRA and taxable balances count in full. The cost is the extra federal tax, the extra state tax, this year's IRMAA, and the extra IRMAA two years later. A 401(k) cashed out before age 60 also loses 10%. An HSA spent on non-medical costs before age 65 also loses 20%.
- **AGI** is other income, plus the taxable part of Social Security, plus required distributions, plus Roth conversions. It matches **Adjusted Gross Income** only when those added pieces are $0.
- **Federal Tax** and **State Tax** are the tax on that year's income. The income is other income, the taxable part of Social Security, required distributions, and Roth conversions. Growth inside a Roth IRA, an HSA, a 401(k), or Taxable is not taxed that year. A withdrawal from a Roth IRA, an HSA, or Taxable is not added to this income.
- **Net Income** is other income, plus the full Social Security benefit, plus required distributions, plus Roth conversions, minus federal tax and state tax. IRMAA is not subtracted here.
- **IRMAA** is that year's Medicare surcharge, in dollars and cents. The cell is a dash when the income year two years earlier is outside the table. The $202.90 standard Part B premium is not included.

Federal tax uses these brackets on income after the standard deduction and the extra senior deduction. The standard deduction is $16,100 if the year is single and $32,200 if it is married. A single person who is 65 or older gets $2,050 more. In a married year, each person who is 65 or older gets $1,650 more.

The extra senior deduction applies if you are 65 or older, or your spouse is. When both of you are 65 or older and the year is married, the amount is $12,000. It falls in a straight line from $150,000 of income to $250,000, and it is $0 at $250,000. In every other case the amount is $6,000. It falls in a straight line from $75,000 to $175,000, and it is $0 at $175,000. The income that shrinks it is other income plus required distributions plus Roth conversions. Social Security is not in that test.

The top of each federal bracket is the taxable income through which that rate applies. Taxable income is what remains after the deductions.

Rate	Single, through	Married, through
10%	$12,400	$24,800
12%	$50,400	$100,800
22%	$105,700	$211,400
24%	$201,775	$403,550
32%	$256,225	$512,450
35%	$640,600	$768,700
37%	No top	No top

Social Security can be partly taxable. Provisional income is other income, plus required distributions, plus Roth conversions, plus half the benefit. None of the benefit is taxable at or below $25,000 if you are single, or at or below $32,000 if you are married. Up to half the benefit is taxable from there to $34,000 single, or to $44,000 married. Above those amounts, up to 85% of the benefit is taxable.

7. Click a year in **Summary**. You should see the row highlighted, and **How the spendable amount was calculated** under the table. The year you clicked is at the top of that box.
8. Drag the right edge of a column heading if a heading is clipped. That column changes width. Rest the pointer on a heading that has a short definition, and you should see that definition.

The spendable panel has two blocks. **Balances at the end of** the year lists Roth IRA, Taxable, 401(k), and HSA, then **Total**. When **Spouse Birth Year** is set, the 401(k) line splits into **401(k), you** and **401(k), spouse**. The HSA line splits the same way.

Cost of cashing out what is left lists these lines, in this order.

- **Federal tax on this year's income**, and **Federal tax if 401(k) and HSA are cashed out**.
- **State tax on this year's income**, and **State tax if 401(k) and HSA are cashed out**.
- **Extra income tax**, the difference between those pairs.
- **401(k) early-withdrawal penalty**, 10% of a 401(k) balance when that person is under 60.
- **HSA non-medical penalty**, 20% of an HSA balance when that person is under 65.
- **IRMAA due in** the selected year.
- **IRMAA in** the year two years later **from this year's income**.
- **IRMAA in** that later year **if 401(k) and HSA are cashed out**.
- **Extra IRMAA from cashing out**, the difference between those two later IRMAA lines.
- **Spendable**, which is **Total** minus extra income tax, the penalties, this year's IRMAA, and extra IRMAA.

This year's federal income tax stays in **Net Income**. It is not subtracted again from the ending balances. If this year's IRMAA depends on a year before the table, that IRMAA is not subtracted. If nobody in the table is on Medicare two years later, cashing out adds no later IRMAA.

At the bottom of the panel, the heading is **Federal tax paid in each bracket**. The same year is under that heading. The next line says these taxes are calculated for Married Filing Jointly, or that they are calculated for a Single filing. Ordinary income is the income after the deduction. You should see a rate, the ordinary income taxed at that rate, and the tax. The lines add up to the federal tax in the cost list. When cashing out would not

change the brackets, one list appears, labeled **This year's income**. When it would, a second list appears, labeled **If the 401(k) and HSA are cashed out**. If the deduction covers the income, the list says "No federal tax. The deduction covers this income."

9. Choose the **Roth IRA**, **HSA**, or **Taxable** tab of **Year-by-Year Projection**. You should see **Year**, **Age**, **Starting Balance**, **Contribution**, **Withdrawal**, **Growth**, and **Ending Balance**. **Age** matches **Summary**. A zero contribution, withdrawal, or growth is a dash.
10. Choose the **401(k)** tab. You should see those same columns, plus **RMD** and **IRMAA Income**. **Withdrawal** here is the required distribution, Roth conversions, and any scheduled withdrawal. **RMD** is the required distribution only. **IRMAA Income** is other income, plus the taxable part of Social Security, plus required distributions, plus Roth conversions. That figure sets the IRMAA two years later. Click a year. You should see **How IRMAA was calculated** under this table.

A required distribution leaves the 401(k). When **Taxable** is on, the amount after tax on that distribution is added to the taxable balance. When **Taxable** is off, that cash is not added to another balance on the chart. A Roth conversion leaves the 401(k). It is deposited in the Roth IRA when the Roth IRA switch is on. Tax withheld from the conversion is not deposited. When the Roth IRA is off, the conversion is not deposited there.

The IRMAA panel uses the year you clicked. People age 65 or older are on Medicare. Before **Marriage Year**, your spouse is not counted, and the year is single. If nobody is 65 yet, the fee is $0. The lookback year is the year two years earlier. If that year is before the table, the surcharge is not calculated. The 2028 surcharge uses 2026 IRMAA income. The brackets are 2026 amounts, and they are not inflated.

IRMAA income in the year lists **Other income**, **Taxable Social Security**, **RMD**, **Roth conversions**, and **IRMAA MAGI**. **Other income** is **Adjusted Gross Income** for that year, after **Only the first year**. **Taxable Social Security** is the taxable part of the benefit from the provisional income test. **IRMAA MAGI** is the sum of the four pieces. The note under the lines says this MAGI sets the premium two years later. Tax-exempt interest is not an input, so this MAGI matches the **AGI** column.

IRMAA fee paid in the year names the lookback year and its MAGI when that year is inside the table. You should see single, or married filing jointly. It names the tier from **IRMAA Bracket Cap**. It names the Part B monthly surcharge and the Part D monthly surcharge. The annual fee is that monthly sum, times 12, times the number of people on Medicare.

Choose the conversions

The switch is on your **401(k)** only. It is labeled **Maximize ending money**. It starts on. Your spouse's 401(k) has the conversion limits from the 401(k) tab, and it does not have this switch. While the switch is off, the table uses the contributions and withdrawals you typed. It does not search for conversions.

1. Open your **401(k)**. **Maximize ending money** is already on. You should see a status box under the title, and **Maximize at age** under the switch. The sample age is 90. Both conversion periods start on for you and for your spouse. Both brackets are 37%. **Pay Roth Conversion Taxes from Taxable Account** starts on.

2. Set **Maximize at age** to your age for the result you care about. This age is yours, not your spouse's. You should see the hint "Primary age. The table still runs through longevity." If this age is later than longevity, the table runs through this age too. After this age you should see no more conversions. Required distributions and the withdrawals you entered still happen.
3. Leave the slider at **Spendable**. You should see "A dollar still in a 401(k) or HSA counts only after the tax, penalty, and extra IRMAA to cash it out." Move the slider to **Total**. You should see "A dollar still in a 401(k) or HSA counts as a dollar." A point between the ends shows "Cash-out tax, penalty, and extra IRMAA count at" and then the percent. The **Total** column and the **Spendable** column do not change meaning.
4. Release the slider. The planner uses the place where you let go. It does not use the place where the handle is still moving. Under the slider, a note starts "Chooses each year's Roth conversion so the money left at this age is as large as possible."
5. Turn off **Pre-RMD Roth Conversions** or **RMD Roth Conversions** on either 401(k) to block that period. A required distribution still happens when the RMD switch is off. On a period you leave on, choose the bracket and **IRMAA Bracket Cap**.

Read the status box under the title while the switch is on. The exact search is the planner's search for conversion amounts. It stops after 60 seconds. You should see one of these.

- A blue box reads "Maximizing. The table updates as a better plan is found." The rows can change more than once. A changing table is not the finished plan.
- A green box at **Total** reads "Exact plan. Conversions maximize the total money left at age" and then the age. The next sentence is "A 401(k) or HSA is counted in full."
- A green box at **Spendable** reads "Exact plan. Conversions maximize the spendable money left at age" and then the age. A pretax account is a 401(k) or an HSA. The sentence then says "after the tax to cash out pretax accounts."
- A green box between the ends reads "Exact plan. Conversions maximize the money left at age" and then the age, then "counting" and the percent, then "of the cost to cash out a 401(k) or HSA."
- An amber box reads "Showing the best plan found. The exact search did not finish, so this may not be the proven maximum."

If conversion tax must come from the taxable balance and that balance cannot cover it, the search drops that plan. The box can then be amber.

Save the plan

The buttons are in the header, next to the title. Nothing is stored until you use them.

1. Click **Save**. You should see a download named `retirement-plan.json`, and the status line "Saved retirement-plan.json".
2. Click **Load** and choose that file. You should see "Loaded from" and then the file name. If the page has changed since the last load, you should first see "Are you sure? This will replace the plan on this page." Cancel to keep the page. The status then reads "Load canceled".
3. Click **Copy**. You should see "Copied to clipboard", or "Couldn't copy. Check clipboard permission."

4. Click **Paste**. You should see "Loaded from the clipboard", or the same replace question as **Load**. If the clipboard cannot be read, the status is "Couldn't read the clipboard."

A file that is not JSON shows "Not valid JSON." A file that is not a plan shows "This is not a retirement plan." A file the browser cannot read shows "Couldn't read that file."

Roth IRA contributions have no income limit on this page. Growth inside a Roth IRA, an HSA, a 401(k), or Taxable is not taxed when it happens. The **IRMAA** column never includes the $202.90 standard Part B premium. Tax-exempt interest has no field of its own.